If You Love Something (Set It Free)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/67051543.

Rating:	Teen And Up Audiences
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationships:	Adora/Catra (She-Ra), 2.5 Seconds of, Adora (She-Ra)/Teela (He-Man)
Characters:	Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Teela (He-Man)
Additional Tags:	Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Angst and Feels, Break Up, Post-Break Up, Break Up and Make Up, High School Sweeathearts, Dating Through College, Temporary Break Up, Mutual Pining
Language:	English
Stats:	Published: 2025-06-30 Words: 5,665 Chapters: 1/1

If You Love Something (Set It Free)

by ResFlower

Summary

"I miss you too. So, so, much." The words are wholly inadequate for what Adora's gone through but she doesn't want to make Catra feel any worse than she already does.

Catra lets out a watery laugh. "Whose bright idea was this, anyway?"

Adora's smile wobbles but she laughs with her. "Yours, genius."

Adora will never forget the day Catra asked her if they could take a break. It had been a few days after she accepted her seat in FZ University for her 18-month Master's program.

It was a warbled request in between a long rant about how couples grow to resent each other in long distance relationships. How they both owed it to each other to grow as people and make sure they weren't one of those high school sweethearts that grew to hate each other right after they got married.

She couldn't believe it then, sitting on Catra's bed as her soon-to-be ex-girlfriend looked at her nervously. Adora had been looking at train schedules to figure out how often she could visit, but Catra was on a whole other page. One that didn't have her written into it.

OR

Catra and Adora break up while Catra is getting her degree in another city. Mandatory Break Up AU.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

One

Catra barely looks at Adora before she sits down in the back of Adora's pickup truck. She can't help but glance over at Catra, now sitting beside her. Her hair has grown longer since Adora last saw her—almost six months to the day.

She holds her hands tightly together between her knees to keep them from shaking. Sitting in the bed of her truck feels *almost* normal, if not for the tense silence between them.

Adora bites her lip, considering Catra. "So... how is it going?" She winces. She couldn't have asked a more awkward question.

"It's going." Catra sighs, her eyes on her boots. She hasn't looked over at Adora even once. "This master's degree is the hardest thing I've ever done."

Her voice trembles and it makes Adora's heart pang. These six months have been the hardest of her life too—not because of anything academic, but because she hasn't been with Catra.

Adora clears her throat. "You're getting it done, though." She knows Catra can do this. She's the smartest person Adora knows, and she's never seen Catra fail when she puts her mind to something.

Slowly, so slowly she's not even sure it's happening, Catra leans closer until their shoulders are touching. "I miss you." It's a broken sob, and it's all the permission Adora needs to take Catra into her arms outright.

Adora places her chin atop Catra's head. She's tempted to drop a kiss there, but she doesn't. "I miss you too. So, so, much." The words are wholly inadequate for what Adora's gone through but she doesn't want to make Catra feel any worse than she already does.

Catra lets out a watery laugh. "Whose bright idea was this, anyway?"

Adora's smile wobbles but she laughs with her. "Yours, genius."

Adora will never forget the day Catra asked her if they could take a break. It had been a few days after she accepted her seat in FZ University for her 18-month Master's program.

It was a warbled request in between a long rant about how couples grow to resent each other in long distance relationships. How they both owed it to each other to grow as people and make sure they weren't one of those high school sweethearts that grew to hate each other right after they got married.

She couldn't believe it then, sitting on Catra's bed as her soon-to-be ex-girlfriend looked at her nervously. Adora had been looking at train schedules to figure out how often she could visit, but Catra was on a whole other page. One that didn't have her written into it.

Adora argued the point a few times, but Catra kept shaking her head. Her jaw was set and her brow furrowed in a way Adora knew well—she knew there was no talking Catra out of it.

She'd already made up her mind, and Adora couldn't deny her that—couldn't impose herself on Catra if she wasn't wanted. They both cried and clung to each other for hours until Adora finally found the strength somewhere to go home.

Catra shoves her shoulder lightly. "Shut up." She takes a deep breath. "It'll be good. We'll know for sure." She repeats again.

Adora presses her lips into a thin line. She doesn't need this test that Catra's arranged for them. Adora already knows—has always known—that Catra is the one for her. She's known that she loves Catra since before she knew what love is. But if Catra needs this, then Adora is powerless but to give her what she wants.

"Okay."

Catra glances at her, tears mostly dried now. "How's everything in Bright Moon?"

Adora looks up at the stars for a moment, collecting her thoughts. "Work is good. I think I'm finally getting the hang of it." It's the easiest thing to admit to. She can't tell Catra about how awful the rest of it has been—about how much she misses her and wishes she'd let Adora back in again.

"That's great. I knew you would." She can hear the pride in Catra's voice, and it makes her knees feel weak. There was a time when she always knew that Catra was proud of her. Now, it feels like a novelty that she has to hold onto with both hands.

"Have your grades come out?" She's been wondering about how Catra has been doing at school this whole time and she finally gets to know.

"Not yet." She groans, putting her head in her hands for a brief second before straightening up. "It'll be next week, probably."

Adora's heart sinks in her chest. "Shame. I would've liked to know." It's going to be so long before she hears from Catra again and this is just a reminder. Adora won't get to know because it's not her place any longer. She sighs. "I'll just assume you got straight As." She aims for lighthearted, but it falls flat.

It's silent between them again. Not as tense as before, but close. "I'm sorry." Catra finally chokes out.

"Why?" She has no idea what Catra is sorry for, and she's almost sure that whatever this apology is, it's not the one she wants anyway.

They aren't touching anymore. Catra is wrapping her arms around herself and she looks so small like that. She's looking at Adora as she rests her head on her knees which are tucked up close to her body.

"I feel like you're mad at me."

Adora pushes down the irritation she feels. That's not a real apology for anything. Of course, Adora is upset. She hates this and she wishes they'd never agreed to it. But she can't force

Catra to come to the conclusion Adora's already arrived at. And she doesn't want to start a fight on the one day they agreed to check in after months of not speaking.

"I'm not angry—not anymore." Adora sighs. It *is* true. She's not angry right now so much as sad. "I just miss you." She wishes things could be different but wishing doesn't help anything now. She'd agreed to respect the boundaries that Catra set and she's committed to seeing it through, so long as it's what Catra wants.

"Only one more year." Catra sighs.

Adora nods her head. In a year, Catra will be done with her degree and she and Adora will have a chance to redefine their relationship. "One more year."

Two

Adora knows she shouldn't text Catra, but it's her birthday. She's never field to wish her happy birthday and she can't not say it now. She thinks calling would definitely be over the line, but maybe a text would be okay?

Her fingers tremble as she holds her phone, looking at the message critically.

Happy birthday. I hope 22 is everything you want it to be.

She presses the send button, hoping against hope that it'll be alright. Adora has been trying her best to respect Catra's wishes but she'd be lying if she said she wasn't struggling with them lately.

They used to spend almost every waking moment together. Adora knows that isn't exactly great, but going from that to never speaking is mind numbingly difficult. She expects it to get easier with time but somehow, it only gets harder.

Every day, she has dozens of thoughts she wants to share with Catra—stupid jokes and questions and compliments and thoughts that are just for her. That make her want pull out her phone and call her. Or better yet, drive to her school and not leave until Catra gives her something more than this.

A part of her is angry that she's been asked to do this. It's one thing for Catra to say she doesn't want to do long distance, but their friendship is different. She can go without kissing Catra—barely, but she can—but not knowing anything about her life is slowly tearing her apart.

Even through her anger, she knows the point Catra made is a valid one. If they were texting back and forth like they used to when they were just friends, Adora would never look away. She'd wait for her phone calls and texts, for any hint of Catra she could get her hands on. It would be all the emotional parts of dating and for all intents and purposes would put them right where Catra didn't want them.

It’s been fifteen minutes and Adora thinks of deleting the message when she sees Catra is typing back.

Her heart thuds loudly in her chest as the three dots on the bottom of her screen appear and disappear at least five times. She’s about to give up when finally, a message pops up.

Thanks. Mostly just studying but it’s been fine. See you in 4 months.

It’s a dry message but it gives Adora a few mental images to ponder. She wonders if Catra is studying at the library or in her dorm. If she’s in a group or by herself and whether she feels confident. Her heart aches as she thinks of how little she knows.

Four months until their next check-in. It feels impossibly far away in every way imaginable. They aren’t even halfway through Catra’s degree yet.

Three

She thinks that she can visit her family, and the city is big enough that she doesn’t have to worry about alerting Adora of her presence in town. She briefly thinks about reaching out—about asking Adora to see her, but it doesn’t feel fair or right. Not when Adora tries so hard to adhere to their agreements. Catra can do the same.

Catra figures the odds of running into Adora in Bright Moon are next to zero, but she’s sorely mistaken. It’s worse than that though—not only does she run into Adora, she approaches her ex-girlfriend at the worst possible time, realizing a few seconds too late exactly what she’s run into. She wasn’t going to run the other way when she saw Adora walking in the shopping district, but now she wishes she had.

“Oh Adora, is this your friend?” The woman is tall with a blindingly white smile as she reaches out to shake Catra’s hand.

Catra wants to die on the spot as she watches those perfectly manicured fingers latch onto Adora’s arm. She watches dumbly as actually shakes hands with the woman Adora is obviously on a date with.

Adora smiles tightly, her eyes glancing between Catra and her date like she’d wished Catra wouldn’t have popped up. That might hurt more than the fact that she has a date.

“Teela, this is Catra. She’s my best friend.” Adora glances back at Catra, her face softening. “How have you been?”

Catra bites her bottom lip so hard she’s worried it might split open right in front of Adora and her shiny new girlfriend. She hates that Adora looks at her as if she cares, when she’s out with someone else. She hates that she’s seen it, that the thought of Adora meeting other women isn’t just confined to her darkest nights after tossing and turning her bed, missing Adora.

“I’m doing great. I have to go now.” She finds the strength to turn to the stranger hanging off Adora’s arm and give her a curt nod. “Nice to meet you.”

She thinks she hears Adora call her name, but it might be wishful thinking.

Catra doesn’t stop walking until she’s made it out to a creek she remembers from when they were kids. Her fingertips are numb by the time she stops, and she thinks it might have taken her an hour to get there, maybe two.

She and Adora would spend many afternoons sitting here after school. When they were younger, they’d play near the water’s edge but as they got older, they’d kiss, huddled together in the relative solace they found.

She kicks a rock and it goes flying into the creek, the water rippling out for a moment before the current blurs it away. This is exactly what she’d wanted, she reminds herself, but it tastes like ash in her mouth. She’d told Adora to explore, to open herself up to opportunities so if they got back together, she would have no doubts that this was what she wanted.

It doesn’t matter much now, though. She hates how perfect that girl and Adora look together. How Adora took one look at her and called Catra her best friend.

She used to *love* being Adora’s best friend. Even after they started dating, she remembers Adora murmuring telling her as much with a bright smile on her face. It felt like it honored the part of their life that was friendship—a lifelong friendship that served as an immovable foundation for their relationship.

It didn’t feel like that when she heard Adora say it tonight. It felt like a half truth, some explanation that wouldn’t make her date awkward.

Adora was well within her rights, but it still stings. Adora is her best friend but she’s more than that. She’s her longest friend, her family, the love of her life.

Not for the first time, she curses herself for being stubborn.

She sits by the side of the creek until her whole body feels cold and she gets a call from her mom, worried about where Catra is. As she makes her way back to her childhood home, she wonders if she’ll ever walk to that creek with Adora again.

Four

It’s unfortunate that their check-in is two weeks after Catra’s disastrous run-in with Adora and her date. She managed to not reach out to Adora since then, but she hasn’t been able to think of anything else but this day. She’s barely been able to sleep wondering about it. She’ll probably find out more about whatever Adora is doing with that girl. Is it serious? Does she already know that she’s not interested in getting back together with Catra? Is she annoyed that Catra interrupted her date?

When Adora tells her that she's not seeing anyone anymore, Catra can't help but try to dig deeper, her anxiety pushing her to ask more questions.

"It wasn't a good fit," is all that Adora offers as an explanation.

It's not enough for her. "You sure? You seemed really into each other."

Adora looks away, clearly uncomfortable. "Yes, I'm sure."

It doesn't stop Catra from pushing. "You don't have to spare me—"

"Catra." Adora calls sharply, anger dripping off of her name in a way Catra can never recall it sounding. "You don't get to do this."

Instead of shrinking, she feels her chest puff out and her spine straighten. "What?"

She sends Catra a level look. "You don't get to be mad at me for doing exactly what you asked of me."

"I'm not mad." She denies hotly.

"Please." Adora rolls her eyes. "It was obvious when you ran into Teela and I, and it's obvious now. You're looking for any little thing to fight over and it's not fair."

"Well, can you blame me?" Catra shakes her head. This conversation has gotten away from her, but she can't find a way to let go of her righteous indignation. "How would you feel if I was flaunting some woman in front of you?"

"Like shit." Adora says plainly. "But one—I wasn't flaunting anything, I didn't even know you were in town—" She tosses an accusatory look Catra's way. "—and two, I never asked for this."

"For what?"

"For this break up!" Adora's face is red, her neck straining as she yells. "*You* didn't want us to have regrets. *You* were worried about what it would mean, if we didn't see what else was out there." She takes a heaving breath. "So, I went on a date with a nice girl. Because it's been a year and it feels like we're nowhere closer to getting back together—and this was the whole fucking point, wasn't it?"

"Sure, but that doesn't make it hurt less!" Catra snaps back. "It still feels like shit that you even want to try."

Adora's jaw is clenched in frustration. "Catra, I can't do both. I can't be loyal and faithful to you when we aren't even together and act like I'm single—which is what I am. Which is what *you chose*."

She sighs, feeling herself deflating. She knows she's being unfair. "I know."

Adora looks like she's had the wind knocked out of her too, sending Catra a searching gaze. "Baby, I just need to know what you want from me." It's a warm whisper, and much kinder than anything Catra deserves.

What she wants is for Adora to tell her this is all stupid—to plead with her to get back together. It's unfair, she knows. Adora is being patient, seeing her way through this at Catra's suggestion. But just because it's unfair doesn't mean it isn't what she wishes would happen—that Adora will kiss her, that she'll demand they never be apart again.

Adora doesn't do that. She waits Catra—watching her with an unnatural stillness. A part of Catra hates it—hates that Adora is giving her what she wants, that's it's been a year since she's really touched Catra. It's hard to remember the point of being apart—it makes her want to give in.

Except for the little voice in her head. The one that tells her that Adora is only with her because they met in first grade and have never parted since. The one that nags at her constantly that she's holding Adora back—that the best thing she could do for Adora is given her the chance to be far away from Catra.

She needs to find a way to silence that voice, and they've already made it this far. If she gives in now, she'll still wonder and she doesn't know that she can live her life like that, always waiting for Adora to find something different, something more, and leave her.

"I think we should stay like this. We said at least until my masters ended, right?" She's not sure if she's making a mistake or not but she has to see this through.

It takes a minute, but Adora nods slowly. "We did say that."

"Then that's what we should do." Catra clears her throat, trying to banish the tightness there. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to get jealous it's just—hard."

Hard doesn't even begin to cover it. She's struggled to go to sleep every day since that day wondering if she's fucked up by getting what she wanted—by pushing Adora away and letting her choose different. Try as she might, she'll never see Adora as anything but hers. The thought of another woman touching her makes her physically ill and clearly, she's not handling it well.

She watches Adora's jaw relax, and her eyes grow sad. "I know. It's okay." She sucks in a harsh breath. "I get it. Really. I don't know what I'd do in your shoes." The tightness in Adora's voice does a lot to soothe her, fucked up as it is. "How are you?"

"Master's is fine. I've made some new friends I think you'll like."

She actually thinks Scorpia and Adora might not be the best of friends, especially since Scorpia tried to ask her out when they first met. Catra hardly entertained the thought before politely declining. Catra knows her heart lies with Adora. She just needs to know Adora feels that way too.

“Cool. Maybe one day I’ll get to meet them.” Her voice is cautious, and that makes Catra sad.

The rest of the check-in goes as well as it can be given that they’re in this holding pattern. Catra hasn’t fully lost Adora yet it seems, but there’s still time for that to change. She’ll be walking around with a heavy stone in her gut until then.

Five

“Catra!’” Adora calls out loudly, cupping her hands together so she can be heard over the sea of graduates. “This way!”

Her smile is blinding as she makes her way over to Adora, pulling her into a short hug. Adora can’t help but pull her tight, the first real hug they’ve had in months. It’s not marred with sadness like the last few hugs they’ve shared, There’s no real room for sadness today. Not on Catra’s graduation.

“You’re here!” Catra takes a step back, her smile growing shy. “I wasn’t sure you’d make it.”

Adora bites her lip, her heart clenched. “I wouldn’t miss it for the world.” She can’t believe that Catra thought, even for a moment, that Adora would do anything but be supportive of her. “This is your dream.”

She’d always wanted to accomplish this, to be the first person in her family to have a graduate degree, and now she has. Adora couldn’t be prouder.

Catra gives her a long look, before glancing away. She puts her hand on her cap to keep it from flying off with the wind. “It’s not my only dream.” She offers as she looks at Adora intently.

Adora’s heart clenches in her chest before it thuds heavily. She hopes that whatever Catra’s dreams are for the future, she has a place in them.

“You’ll get it all.” It’s not her promise to make but she makes it anyway. She glances over at Catra’s family all clamoring behind her to pull her into an embrace. “Don’t let me keep you. I’ll be right here.” She steps aside and takes in Catra’s grateful smile as she hugs her grandma and then her mom.

Adora is strung out from a weird mix of nerves and joy. This is all she’s ever wanted for Catra and watching her make it through such a rigorous program and now having the chance to celebrate with her family is heartwarming. There was a point in time when she wasn’t even sure if Catra would invite her, but she’s so glad she did.

On the other hand, this is what Catra said they were waiting for. She has her degree. Adora doesn’t know what it means for them exactly—she’s not sure if Catra has a job lined up in Bright Moon, or whether she wants Adora back at all—but it has to mean *something* one way or the other.

She knows there's a chance that Catra is waiting on her to say something. They'd agreed to stay apart until at least Catra's graduation and the day is here. Yet, Adora can't bring herself to broach the topic. What if Catra isn't ready?

Adora didn't understand why Catra wanted this to start, but she's grown to appreciate their time apart. In some ways, she took for granted how well Catra knows her—the way that Catra loves her. Being away from her has forced Adora to grow and change in a number of ways, but none that made her any less devoted to Catra. She's just not sure the same could be said about Catra.

"Are you two figuring things out?"

Adora snaps her head up to look at Catra's dad. He has a raised eyebrow as he looks at her and she feels her cheeks warm with embarrassment.

Being broken up with Catra has been awful, but the most awkward part of it has been finding the right things to say to their families. She still saw Catra's parents from time to time—they've always been a huge part of her life—but it's definitely not the same as when she was constantly over to be with Catra.

"I'm not sure." She shrugs. "I think it's really for Catra to decide."

He groans, throwing his hands up in the air. "I was hoping you wouldn't say that."

"Why not?"

He sighs. "I love my daughter, but sometimes she can get stuck if she doesn't know the perfect outcome to something. I worry that she's stuck."

Adora frowns. "Catra is smart. She'll figure out what she wants. I believe in her."

"And what about what you want?" He puts a comforting hand on her shoulder. "Are you alright?"

"I'm fine." She bites her lip. Adora knows what she wants—she just needs Catra to want her back. "I'll wait for now."

"But not forever, I hope?" He searches her expression for something. "I don't want you to put your life on hold, Adora. You deserve happiness too."

She swallows the knot that bubbles up in her throat. "Not forever."

Adora can't make Catra choose her, but she also can't wait on her for some indefinite amount of time. Now that Catra's degree is completed, she's not sure how much longer she can hang her hopes on Catra loving her.

She'll shove that aside for today, though. She doesn't want to make Catra's big day about them, but she resolves to have that conversation soon.

And One

Catra knocks on the door before she can think too hard about it. She's already overthought everything about this for the last year and a half. She tries to convince herself she's already done the hard part—asking Marlena for Adora's new address had been damn near mortifying—but she knows that's not true.

She's so afraid of what might happen—honestly, of what she expects to happen. It's been so long since things between her and Adora were right and she's the one who messed it all up. She can't blame Adora if she decides that she's had enough of Catra's bullshit.

The door swings open, interrupting her train of thought.

"Catra?"

Adora's light eyes are wide with surprise as they scan her. She looks beautiful as ever, even in a worn out t-shirt from their high school's softball team and a pair of shorts with cartoons on them.

"Hey Adora." She tries to smile past the nerves. "Can we talk?"

She braces herself for rejection, but it doesn't come.

"Of course." She opens the door wider, letting her in.

Immediately, a bouncing fluff ball comes into view. Swifty practically barrels into her legs, although he doesn't seem to recognize her at first. She can tell when he does though, because his tail starts wagging and he puts his paws up, trying to hop as close to her face as he can.

"Swifty, no!" Adora nudges her dog, pulling him back so Catra can walk in. She shoots Catra an apologetic smile. "I'm sorry. You know how he gets."

Catra feels a knot in her throat—she does, but she hasn't seen him in well over a year now. "I'm surprised your parents let you keep him."

She shrugs. "Adam wanted to get a big dog, and my parents wanted to travel more after retirement. It made sense for me to take Swifty." She pets the top of his head, leaning down to reach. "He just needed some time to adjust, and it was right as rain." Adora stands back up as he calms down and walks off to his bed. She reaches up to her neck, rubbing it. "Sorry. You probably didn't come here to talk about Swifty."

The heavy-handed hint sits in the air, her eyes curious—clearly wondering why Catra showed up to her doorstep unannounced.

She takes a deep breath. "I want to talk about us."

Adora exhales sharply and nods. "Okay. Let's talk, then." She walks deeper into her apartment, turning to look back at Catra. She's fidgeting with her hands, something Catra knows she does when she's nervous. "Do you want something to drink?"

She shakes her head quickly—she needs to keep her nerves so that she can actually do what she's set out to. "I'm fine."

Adora bites her lip before leading Catra to her living room, sitting down on the couch. She pats the seat next to her with a soft smile. Catra sits but she kind of feels like she might throw up. She thinks Adora would have said if she didn't want her but what if she figured Catra would know from her silence? It's been two months since Catra moved back to Bright Moon and Adora has made no move to contact Catra.

"I guess before I start, I want to know...is there someone else?" Catra braces herself for the answer. She tries to keep her expression as neutral as she can, not daring to let her hopes get to high.

Adora bites her lip and shakes her head. "No. Not at all."

"Okay...that's good." She lets out a breath. "I mean, not good, you know but—" Catra scolds herself, looking away. "I'm doing this all wrong."

She's surprised when she feels something warm in her lap. When she looks down, Adora's fingers are interlaced with hers. "You can't do this wrong—whatever 'this' is." She's smiling softly, eyes on Catra as she nudges closer on the couch.

Fuck, she forgot how loud her heart gets when she's this close to Adora. "I wanted to check in. About maybe—we could try again?"

It's weak, almost a whimper of a question but Adora beams like she's never wanted anything more. She leans forward, her forehead pressing against Catra. "I've known since I was seven years old that I want to marry you." It's a hushed whisper, a confession Catra feels wholly undeserving of. "There's nothing I'd love more."

She blinks. Catra came her prepared to apologize and explain herself and then have her heart broken. Not even for a moment did she think Adora would just accept her without any fuss.

"Just like that?"

Adora lets out a laugh before raising her eyebrow. "What, like this being a year and a half in the making isn't enough?"

"No, but also—yes? I mean—you haven't reached out at all. I thought you weren't interested."

Adora lets out a quiet sigh, her hand coming up to cup Catra's cheek. "You have no idea how hard it's been to not knock down your door and beg you to take me back."

That sounds like exactly what Catra had been dying for this whole time. "Then why didn't you?" She huffs out, frustrated. She isn't entitled to Adora's love, she knows, but she's still selfish enough to want it.

"Because you asked me for space." Adora's eyes look wet, her teeth worrying her lower lip. "You wanted to be sure that us together would work. If I pushed you, and you gave in—

you'd still have doubts." She closes her eyes for a moment, her eyelashes fluttering softly. "And honestly Catra, it's not like I knew you'd come back."

"Of course I came back." She can't stand it anymore, pulling Adora into a tight hug—their first in what feels like ages. "I just—I didn't want you to have regrets. To wish you'd chosen something different."

It's what it comes down to—letting go of Adora first, giving her room to run. Because if she lost her like this—holding onto her with all her strength—Catra isn't sure she'll know how to survive it.

She feels Adora's arms tight across her body, one of her hands loose in her hair. "I've never loved anyone the way I love you." She nuzzles Catra close with a short laugh. "And it's all over for you now—good luck trying to get rid of me this time."

"Could be all talk." Catra retorts back, mostly to be a contrarian. She can't get over how good it feels to be held like this again by the person she knows she belongs to.

She feels Adora pull back slightly until she catches Catra's stare. "I want to be clear about something." she says slowly, her face so close that her warm breath puffs over Catra's face. "This whole separation deal was a onetime thing. If you have doubts or you're worried about if I have regrets—*talk* to me, please." She's pleading, her eyes soft and open. "I'm not ever going to want something that isn't this."

"You can't know that." She protests. Catra thought that this time apart would make her feel like she could be sure about things between her and Adora, and she's disappointed to find that nagging voice is still there in the background. The difference now is that Catra is willing to live with that voice, with those insecurities, so long as she gets to have her best friend back.

Adora is unperturbed, shaking her head with a small smile. "I do know it. And one day, you're going to know it too." She promises. "But until then, I'm always going to be willing to soothe your fears, Catra. I just need you to let me."

She nods quickly, pressing her cheeks to Adora's. It's a terrifying and vulnerable proposition—to lay bare her insecurities in front of the person she loves the most. But if their time apart has shown Catra anything, it's that she loves Adora despite any time or distance. That she's willing to do things that are uncomfortable to keep them afloat.

"I promise I will." She takes a shuddering breath. "I want everything we had before and more. And I'm willing to fight for it. Whatever it takes. I'm sorry it took all this to get there."

Maybe if she'd listened to Adora or her parents she would have gotten to this conclusion earlier, but she's honestly not sure. Although their time apart was hard, Catra doesn't know how she'd feel if they hadn't done it—if she constantly felt like she was holding Adora back from afar.

"You don't have to be sorry for asking for what you needed." She runs a hand over Catra's back. "I missed you."

Before Catra can tell Adora how much she's missed her too, her words die on her tongue when she locks eyes with Adora and she tilts Catra's chin softly.

When Adora kisses her, she can swear she's made it home.

End Notes

I had this almost done for an eon and I kept forgetting to finish and then I remembered it existed for like, the seventh time so I finally managed to get it together and finish this up lol. I was in a bit of a piney/hurty mood so it worked out for me. I hope y'all enjoy it.

Also, yes Adam ends up dating Teela and I like imagining Adora and Catra's reaction because it would be so funny.

Kudos and comments make the world go round. You can find me on Twitter and Tumblr.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!